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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

DePaul lays off 114 staff members

Reduction of 7.6% of workers aimed to reduce budget shortfall

By Kate Armanini
Chicago Tribune

DePaul University has laid off 114 staff members to help plug its budget deficit, school officials announced Monday.

The reduction accounts for 7.6% of full-time and part-time staff, according to a message from President Rob Manuel. The university is aiming to reduce \$274 million in spending following a dramatic drop in international enrollment.

“Supporting our students and providing an excellent education remain our top priority,” Manuel wrote. “We want to emphasize that university leaders worked to minimize cuts to the student experience, including on-campus employment.”

DePaul is facing a \$12.6 million budget deficit for the 2026 fiscal year. To maintain long-term sustainability, the university is also aiming for a 2.5% operating margin — which means another \$14.8 million in cuts.

Every area across the university will be affected by staff and operational cuts, DePaul said.

About \$11.4 million in savings will come from eliminating merit raises, a hiring freeze, reducing 403(b) contributions and executive pay cuts. The remaining \$16 million in cuts will come from the layoffs and other operating expense reductions.

Manuel called recent weeks “some of the most difficult our community has ever experienced.” Impacted staff will be provided with severance packages, he said.

DePaul announced in October that there are 755 fewer international students enrolled compared with last fall. The drop was even steeper for first-year international graduate student enrollment, which declined by nearly 62%.

Increased vetting, travel bans

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Ald. Nicole Lee, 11th, talks about an alternative budget during a news conference at Chicago City Hall on Monday. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Aldermen tweak budget plan, but withhold details

Renegade Chicago City Council members looking to find way to get support for deal

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Renegade Chicago aldermen battling with Mayor Brandon Johnson over competing 2026 budgets announced tweaks to their proposal Monday, but withheld critical details as a negotiation meeting between the sides broke down.

The City Council majority group is dropping its plan to raise the garbage pick-up fee and will also maintain youth summer job funding at levels first proposed by Johnson after previously pushing for a smaller amount, its members told reporters Monday. The

changes are an apparent bid to convince more colleagues to join them and blunt Johnson’s near-daily criticism that their package would hurt working-class Chicagoans.

Johnson on Monday initially claimed the change as a win pulling the opposed aldermen’s plan closer to his own and said he has “wiggle room” to negotiate.

“Hopefully this is a sign that, through our advocacy for working people, these members understand the importance of not passing budgets that disproportionately impact people

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Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson, center, speaks after meeting with a group of aldermen to talk about an alternative budget on Monday. TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE



Filmmaker Rob Reiner talks during an interview in Chicago on June 18, 2014. ALEX GARCIA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Son arrested in Reiner deaths

Filmmaker helmed beloved ’80s movies; couple slain at home

By Jake Coyle
Associated Press

Rob Reiner, the son of a comedy giant who became one himself as one of the preeminent filmmakers of his generation with movies such as “The Princess Bride,” “When Harry Met Sally...” and “This Is Spinal Tap,” has died. He was 78.

INSIDE

■ Gov. JB Pritzker mourns Reiners, says he was just with them days ago. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

■ On social media, President Trump blames actor/director’s killing on opposition to him. **Nation & World**

Reiner and his wife, Michele Singer Reiner, were found fatally stabbed Sunday at their home in the Brentwood neighborhood of Los Angeles. The Los Angeles Police Department on Monday

arrested the Reiners’ 32-year-old son, Nick Reiner, and booked him on suspicion of killing his parents. Police Chief Jim McDonnell said he is being held on \$4 million bail.

Nick Reiner has spoken publicly of his struggles with addiction. By 18, he had cycled in and out of treatment facilities with bouts of homelessness and relapses in between.

It was a tragic, shocking end to a life and career that began with a

Turn to Reiner, Page 4

Richton Park tree lot closing after 40 years

Spot was the setting for a 2019 Hallmark Christmas movie

By Paul Eisenberg
Daily Southtown

The Airstream trailer anchoring a roadside Christmas tree pop-up lot in the 2019 Hallmark movie “Christmas Under the Stars” was fictional, but the tree lot setting was not.

Based on a story by Park Forest native Rikk Dunlap, the movie was born in the annual fir-filled lot established each November along Sauk Trail adjacent to Joann’s Food & Liquor in Richton Park.

“I love the holidays and seeing that just always got me into the Christmas spirit,” Dunlap told Daily Southtown columnist Donna Vickroy in 2019, in advance of the movie’s premiere.

While “Christmas Under the Stars” lives on in reruns, its inspiration has become a ghost of Christmas past. Richton Park

Mayor Rick Reinbold, whose family had long operated the pop-up Christmas tree lot, didn’t haul any trees into town this season for the first time in about 40 years.

“We finally had to pull the plug,” he said.

Reinbold said dwindling business over the last four years dictated the closure.

“Two of those years we were breaking even, and for the last two years we were actually losing money,” he said. “We had to decide not to do it this year.”

In its heyday, Reinbold said his family would sell in excess of 600 trees at the Sauk Trail lot in the weeks leading up to Christmas.

“We were down to, if we were lucky, moving 150 trees off the lot,” he said. “It just got to be a numbers decision.”

He said artificial trees were taking a larger share of the market, while box-store tree sales also cut into his business. Beyond the sales numbers, Rein-

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Milder temps are finally on the way

After a frigid start to winter, temperatures are expected to climb above freezing on Tuesday, and milder weather could last through New Year’s. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Blackhawks place Bedard on IR

The Blackhawks placed star center Connor Bedard on injured reserve because of an upper-body injury. He will be reevaluated in January. **Chicago Sports**

